

The Rise of Smart Bands and Smart Watches in Mainstream Consumer Tech

Some argue that smartwatches and smartbands still have a while to go before they achieve mainstream popularity in India. Most Indians view them as an unnecessary piece of technology, and that their marketing strategy is to simply create demand which does not exist. Arguable, who really needs a fitness band or smartwatch? There are a number of fitness apps that use your smartphone's inbuilt sensors to track steps and calculate distance travelled, thus leaving most consumers who buy a smartband with the feeling that they have paid premium bucks for a device whose features were already available in their pocket.

The sudden growth of startups and the widespread adoption of a consumerist lifestyle, especially among the middle class, has arguably led to a drastic deterioration in the average Indian's health. It seems that the market is ripe for products that can help improve failing fitness levels by any means possible. According to the Connected Intelligent Consumers and Wearables report by the NPD group, one in ten adults in the United States owns a fitness tracker. As current trends imply, the Indian market does not seem to be extremely thrilled about wearable, in particular smartbands and smartwatches.

However, the adoption of new technology is always met with some resistance. Before smartphones became not just a common sight but also an essential part of everyday life, they were looked at as expensive devices that could only be afforded by people from higher income blocks. However, their immense potential and scalability were critical factors in their eventual widespread adoption. So much so that smartphones are affordable and available even for people in rural areas. Wearables are slowly progressing to this stage of mainstream marketability.

Currently, wearables fall somewhere between the affordable and expensive price brackets. Top brand smartwatches range between \$80 (₹5,600) to as high as \$1,100 (₹70,000). You can also get a cheaper Chinese model smartwatch for as low as ₹1,500 if you know where to look. Smartbands are generally more affordable. The Mi band is a very popular fitness band, and retails for approximately ₹1,000. Fitbit bands were recently released in India and cost between ₹5,590 and ₹10,390.

India also has its very own smartband offering in GOQii. This company is trying to bypass the technology stigma by offering customers a complete fitness service that includes the assistance of a fitness coach